

out. How fortunate I felt to have intercepted this private gossip between two people in the know, the kind of chance an average investor rarely gets.

"Did you buy some for yourself?"

"Yes," said Ms. Garrett. "So did everybody else in the office."

Was this the opportunity I'd been looking for? A voice from within me that I couldn't control blurted out: "I'll take 5,000 shares." Within minutes, my new Prudential-Bache account was opened, the 5,000-share order was sent in, and I was standing outside in the parking lot. Only then did I realize that: (1) I'd just chosen my new broker by default, (2) I'd ignored my own Tip Number Seven, and (3) 5,000 shares times \$1.50 added up to nearly two-thirds of my investment stake. This putting most of my eggs in one basket made me think of Mr. Loeb.

Down the highway I stopped in a phone booth to call my wife and explain what I'd bought. As I was dialing, I realized I'd forgotten the name of the company, so I hung up before she could answer.